

●●●

NETWORKING A PROPOSAL

To check out the world of online courtship, we sent our reporter into cyberspace. Here's a crash course on the rules of the game.

It's a different language of courtship. The "wheatish complexion, convent educated, homely girl" has been repackaged in a much more direct and personalised jargon. It is ironic but the cyberspace world of romance is much more alive to the nuances of 21st-century arranged marriages than the formatted Sunday matrimonial adverts or the aunt-from-Kanpur who drove to your house with lace curtains in her car and a proposal in her handbag.

"I can take a lotta crap..." is how a 30-something potential groom makes his pitch for a bride on a matrimonial website. Hardly surprising that this alpha male goes by the name of Samson. It is the age of branding and the initial overtures are made through a revealing tagline. So, I had a choice between the high endurance Samson, the 20-something I-am-Cooler or just Lonely@8 who acclaims, "true friends are rare but a relationship is like a castle to build". It is soon revealed that he is simply building castles in air as he adds that he was not offering marriage but "friendship for the time being" as his divorce was still to come through. Clearly a man destined to remain lonely long after eight.

That's the fun of the Internet. You get to go through the awkward first meeting (where five seconds after walking in you want to walk out) without leaving the comfort of your home, or for that matter the comfort of your red track suit. The interaction is so much easier. Without feeling like a shop window display yourself or hurting any egos you can dismiss the man who spent the last weekend watching a movie called 10,000 B.C. as "not my type" and quietly tiptoe away from the engineer who approaches the marriage question as a war strategy, writing, "King Bruce saw the spider and tried and tried till he succeeded. I am still on the way."

With the same spider-like spirit, I too logged in my vital stats i.e. I do not smoke or cook. As opposed to the drawing-room of arranged marriages, this was not a deal

50% members of marriage portals live in the five metros

79% of online matrimony surfers are well-qualified

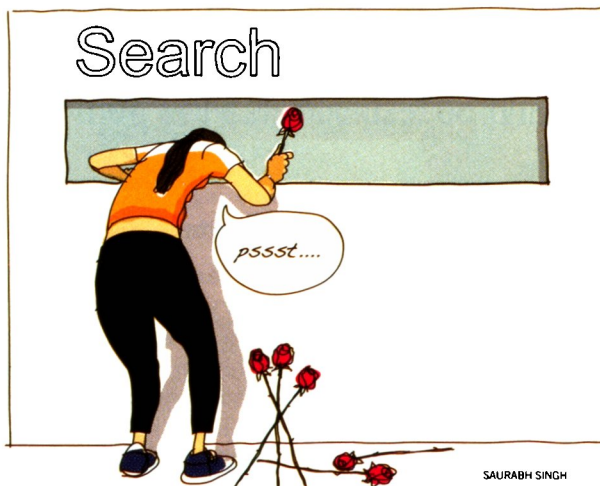
breaker. In cyberspace, where men get to script their own proposals most of the times away from the scrutiny of their relatives, there are enough metro males who say they love to cook. Each profile has a check list of attributes about yourself and what you are looking for in a potential partner. Very few rate fair complexion as one of the essentials. I don't know if this is an indication of a new age health awareness but most women—and men—write a categorical "no" against smoking and drinking. Though one 36-year-old did say that while a strict vegetarian himself, he was okay if his wife ate eggs with his vegetarian cuisine! These kind of pragmatic details

never come out until the third or fourth meeting via the conventional arranged marriage route. Here, one conversation and am already flooded with too much detail. Like how Ever-Ready likes to drink warm tea. Or how Metro Male is looking for a "supportive wife, so I can relax on her shoulder". He takes the role of a supportive wife quite literally though, doesn't he? And my old friend Lonely@8 enjoyed *Taare Zameen Par* but is

against the Indo-US nuclear

deal. Sounds almost like L.K. Advani. Somewhere in all this trivia is a detail that clicks. Like the "Wiseguy" who thought it important enough to mention he hates Calcutta being renamed Kolkata in his profile. That struck a chord—even more than the offer of cooking. So, there could be some quirk that works for you. But if it doesn't, then you don't lose anything. This has all the perks of a blind date except that one of you is not blindfolded. You get to have a sneak peek while revealing only as much of yourself as you want to. That's the charm of the Internet proposal. But it has its limit. It took three emails for Samson to shake his curly locks in disgust and send a terse rebuff my way: "To be honest we can chat as much as we like but nothing eventuates."

Guess, I no longer have mail.



SAURABH SINGH

by Priya Sahgal